

What else to watch: *Bringing Up Baby* (1938) ■ *The Philadelphia Story* (1940) ■ *Roman Holiday* (1953) ■ *The Seven-Year Itch* (1955) ■ *The Apartment* (1960)

and Hildy Johnson, his ex-wife, who is an ace journalist. This switch added a romance angle to the satire, playing with ideas of what men and women want in life.

A woman's dilemma

In the opening scene, Rosalind Russell's Hildy, struggling to get a word in edgewise in a quick-fire verbal sparring match with her ex-husband and ex-boss Walter (Cary Grant), announces that she is about to marry insurance man Bruce Baldwin (Ralph Bellamy).

Bruce is dull, but Hildy says that she wants to escape from the beastly, corrupt world of journalism to become "a human being" who lives a "normal" life as a wife and mother. It's a choice between home and career, but Walter is sure that



Howard Hawks Director

Howard Hawks directed more than 40 classic Hollywood movies, but it was only late in his life that he came to be recognized as one of the directing greats. Born in Goshen, Indiana, in 1896, Hawks moved with his family to California in 1910 and was drawn into the movie business, working briefly as a prop man on a handful of movies such as *The Little American* (1917).

After serving in World War I as an airman, he returned to Hollywood, where he wrote and directed his first movie in 1926,

the silent *Road to Glory*. When he moved into talkies, his 1932 gangster thriller *Scarface* was a huge success, and there followed a string of movies, among them "screwball" comedies with Cary Grant such as *Bringing Up Baby* and *His Girl Friday*. Later movies included movie noir classics such as *The Big Sleep*, and the Western *Rio Bravo* (1959).

Key movies

1932 *Scarface*

1938 *Bringing up Baby*

1940 *His Girl Friday*

1944 *To Have and Have Not*

1946 *The Big Sleep*

the thrill of the press world is too alluring for her to quit as star reporter. The movie revolves around his efforts to remind her of this, as he involves her in an unfolding news story about the upcoming execution of convicted murderer Earl Williams (John Qualen).

Walter behaves outrageously in his efforts to win Hildy back. He barely misses a beat when Molly, the girl who has befriended Williams, leaps to her death from a window. Yet Grant endows Walter with such panache and sheer cleverness that the viewer roots for him as he reels Hildy in. No wonder Hildy says to him, "Walter, you're wonderful, in a loathsome sort of way." And yet

“Who do you think I am, a crook?”

Walter / *His Girl Friday*

Hildy matches him every step of the way, which is why, of course, they are made for each other. ■



The movie uses much of the script from the original play, but Hawks also encouraged the actors to ad-lib.

